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STARTUPS



**Waymo's Tekedra
Mawakana on the truth
behind autonomous
vehicles at TechCrunch
Disrupt 2025**

Autonomous vehicles have long been touted as “just around the corner,” but the reality of what it takes to bring self-driving cars to the streets is anything but simple. At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27–29 at Moscone West in San Francisco, [Waymo](#) co-CEO Tekedra Mawakana joins the [Disrupt Stage](#) for a wide-ranging conversation on the current state of AVs — and where the industry goes from here.

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October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

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TEKEDRA
MAWAKANA

Co-CEO, Waymo

Inside the self-driving reality check

While the headlines often focus on crashes, controversies, or overblown promises, Tekedra has spent years navigating the real-world path to autonomous mobility. At Disrupt, she'll dig into what it actually takes to scale AV deployment — from rider safety and public trust to the nuances of

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regulation, operations, and competitive pressure from Tesla and others.

This session isn't about vague timelines or flashy demos. It's about what's working, what still needs work, and what it means to bring truly autonomous vehicles to life at scale. Whether you're a founder, investor, or just curious about the road ahead, you won't want to miss it.

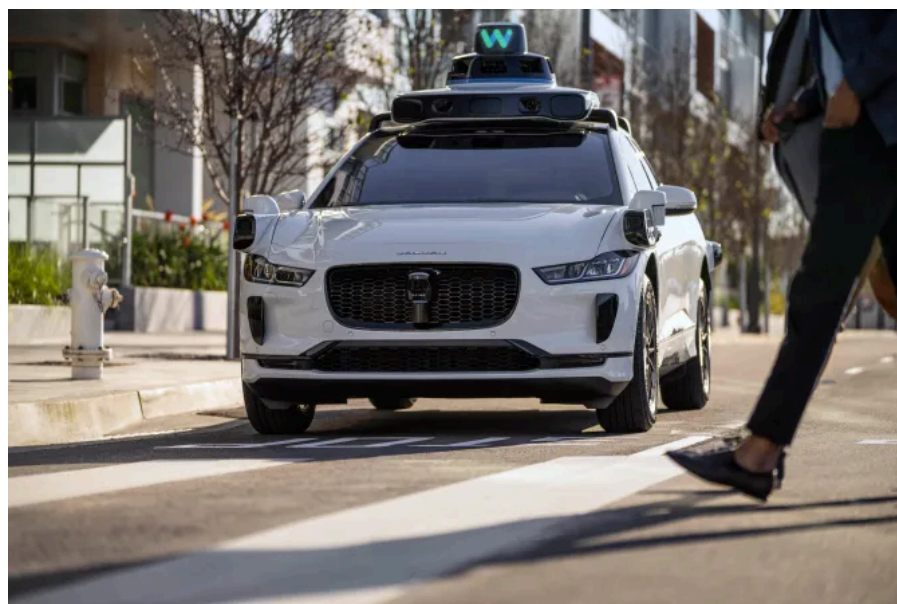


IMAGE CREDITS: WAYMO

Meet the leader behind the wheel

[Tekedra Mawakana](#) brings over two decades of experience shaping global strategy for some of the world's biggest tech companies. As co-CEO of Waymo, she guides the company's long-term mission to bring the Waymo Driver to the masses and lead the next generation of autonomous innovation. She also serves on the board of Intuit, advises Boom Technology, and supports a number of social impact ventures through her work as an investor and LP with Operator Collective.

Get your pass to Disrupt before rates rise

- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

Waymo’s story is a central chapter in the future of mobility, and this session offers a rare inside look at the journey behind the headlines. Join us at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) — where more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders gather to shape what’s next. [Register today](#) and secure your spot with up to \$675 in ticket savings before prices increase.



IMAGE CREDITS:KIMBERLY WHITE / GETTY IMAGES

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STARTUPS



Elad Gil — one of tech's sharpest minds — on early bets, breakout growth, and what's coming next at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:00 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

Elad Gil isn't just ahead of the curve — he practically lives there. Before most of the world had even asked ChatGPT its first question, Gil was writing early checks into companies like Perplexity, Character.AI, and Harvey. And that's just a slice of the story. His track record includes seed or Series A investments in more than 30 unicorns and involvement with some of the most iconic names in tech — Stripe, Airbnb, Coinbase, Instacart, Notion, Figma, Flexport, GitLab, and many more.

This October, Gil takes the [Disrupt Stage](#) at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) in San Francisco for a fireside chat that promises to cover a lot of ground.

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He'll cover everything from his approach to spotting breakout potential early to how he's thinking about the next big wave of innovation. Whether you're building in AI, crypto, health tech, or enterprise SaaS, this conversation is a rare opportunity to hear how one of Silicon Valley's most prolific investors sees the road ahead.

[Register early](#) to pocket real ticket savings and join valuable conversations with startup heavyweights like Gil.



Why this one matters

There are VCs, and then there's [Elad Gil](#). With operating experience at Google and Twitter, multiple founder wins, and a portfolio that reads like a who's who of tech success stories, he brings a rare mix of operator empathy and investor clarity. His bestselling book "High Growth Handbook" is required reading for startup leaders scaling fast, and his ability to decode markets before they shift is second to none.

In this one-on-one, we'll go deep on early-stage investing, new frontier technologies, and what it really takes to build a category-defining company. From the inside out.

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Don't miss the valuable takeaways — only at Disrupt 2025

Join 10,000+ startup and VC leaders [October 27–29 at Moscone West in San Francisco](#). From headline-making sessions to hands-on networking, Disrupt is where the future of tech gets built — and this fireside with Elad Gil is just one of many reasons to be in the room. [Register here](#) to snag your seat for this exclusive discussion.

TC

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

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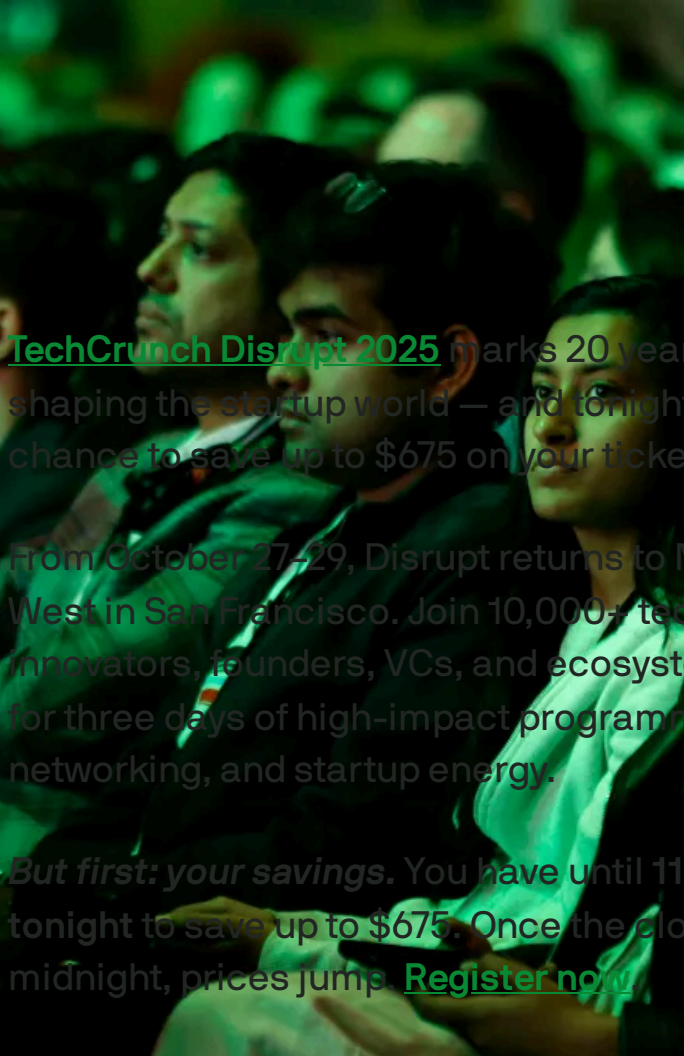
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Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight



[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) marks 20 years of shaping the startup world — and tonight's your last chance to save up to \$675 on your ticket.

From October 27-29, Disrupt returns to Moscone West in San Francisco. Join 10,000+ tech innovators, founders, VCs, and ecosystem builders for three days of high-impact programming, networking, and startup energy.

But first: your savings. You have until 11:59 p.m. PT tonight to save up to \$675. Once the clock strikes midnight, prices jump. [Register now.](#)



24 HOURS LEFT

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Why you won't want to miss this 20th-anniversary Disrupt

TechCrunch Disrupt has been the launchpad for breakthroughs and next-generation deals for 20 years. It's not just another tech conference — it's where game-changing innovations are born, powerful connections are made, and ideas turn into action.

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High costs and thin margins threatening AI coding startups

Marina Temkin - 7 hours ago

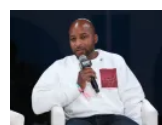
TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



Elad Gil — one of tech's sharpest minds — on early bets, breakout growth, and what's coming next at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events
- 14 hours ago

FUNDRAISING



How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events
- 1 day ago

One session, one meeting, one moment — that's all it takes to change your trajectory. Disrupt is where startups break out, investors find the next big thing, and industry leaders stay ahead of the curve.

Featured Disrupt 2025 speakers

- Roelof Botha, [Sequoia Capital](#)
- Jeff Cardenas, [Apptronik](#)
- David George, [Andreessen Horowitz](#)
- Alex Kendall, [Wayve](#)
- Eunice Kim, [Netflix](#)
- Tekedra Mawakana, [Waymo](#)
- Alejandro Matamala Ortiz, [Runway](#)
- Ryan Petersen, [Flexport](#)
- Mati Staniszewski, [ElevenLabs](#)
- Astro Teller, [X, The Moonshot Factory](#)
- Ethan Thornton, [Mach Industries](#)
- Nirav Tolia, [Nextdoor](#)
- Raquel Urtasun, [Waabi](#)
- Eric Yuan, [Zoom](#)
- Sangeen Zeb, [GV \(Google Ventures\)](#)
- ...and many more. New speakers are announced weekly. [Check the speaker page](#) often.



IMAGE CREDITS:HAJE KAMPS / TECHCRUNCH

Here's what's happening at Disrupt

Four Industry stages + the Disrupt Stage

Dive into the tools, trends, and tactics founders need to grow, scale, and lead in a competitive market. Stay tuned as new sessions are frequently added to [the agenda](#).

- **Builders Stage:** Growth playbooks and founder realities
- **AI Stage:** Two days covering agents, creativity, defense, EV, hardware, and regulation
- **Space Stage:** Where tech meets the cosmos
- **Going Public Stage:** Candid lessons from companies that made it

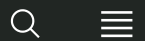
Interactive sessions

Join candid conversations with startup pros in small-group roundtables and breakout sessions. Ask real questions, get unfiltered answers, and gain in-depth insights not covered on the big stages.

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from

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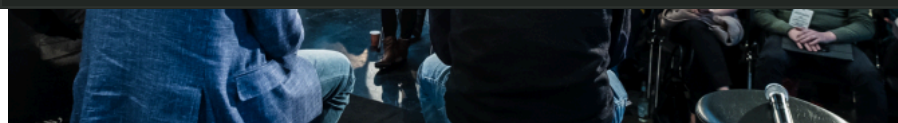


IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Startup Battlefield 200

Watch the top 20 TechCrunch-picked startups pitch live on the Disrupt Stage for a \$100,000 equity-free prize — with real-time VC feedback.

Explore what's next

Step into the Expo Hall and meet the startups creating tomorrow's tech. Founders: Want in? [Exhibit your startup](#) and get in front of investors, media, and future customers, before tables run out.

Make the right connections

Disrupt isn't about meeting *more* people — it's about meeting the *right* ones. Braindate helps you find those key conversations that move your goals forward, whether in a 1:1 or small-group format.

Additional benefits for investors and founders

The Deal Flow Café is where investors and founders connect over coffee to talk deals, raise rounds, and spark momentum.

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In addition to access to the Deal Flow Café, Investor and Founder Pass holders unlock exclusive benefits designed to make an impact:

- **Investors:** Enjoy a curated tour of the Expo Hall with formal introductions to startups that align with your investment focus. Plus, your reserved seat at the exclusive **StrictlyVC** session on Day 2 awaits.
- **Founders:** Get face time with investors actively scouting for their next big bet, whether you're raising now or building for what's next.



IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Savings disappear after tonight

You've got until **11:59 p.m. PT tonight** to save up to \$675 on your Disrupt 2025 ticket. Don't miss one of the most anticipated tech conferences of the year. [Register now](#) and lock in your savings before prices go up after tonight.

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FUNDRAISING



How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 11:48 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 returns to Moscone West in San Francisco from October 27-29, bringing together more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders for an inside look at where innovation is headed. Among the must-attend sessions is a candid panel on the Builders Stage about one of the most high-stakes moments in any founder's journey: raising your first round.

Register now to save up to \$675 on your ticket and join this conversation — plus 200+ more sessions across five industry stages, roundtables, and breakouts. Prices go up tonight at 11:59 p.m. PT.

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MARLON NICHOLS

Co-Founder & Managing General Partner,
MaC Venture Capital

GABBY CAZEAU

Partner,
Harlem Capital

MARIA PALMA

General Partner,
Freestyle Capital

From pitch to partnership: The real roadmap to seed funding

This dynamic panel brings together three seasoned investors — Maria Palma (Freestyle Capital), Gabby Cazeau (Harlem Capital), and Marlon Nichols (MaC Venture Capital) — to unpack the realities of early-stage fundraising. From shaping a compelling pitch to choosing the right capital partners, they'll share honest, actionable insights to help founders translate interest into investment.

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[Maria Palma](#), general partner at [Freestyle Capital](#), brings deep operating and investing experience, with past roles at Kindred Capital, RRE Ventures, and leadership positions at high-growth startups like Eyeview. She's backed companies such as Fung Money, Lightning Labs, and Payman, and holds an MBA from Harvard.

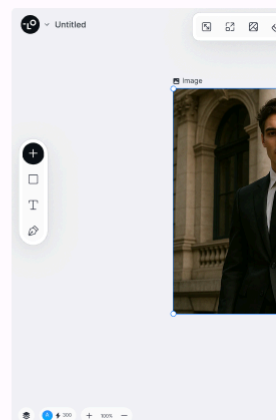
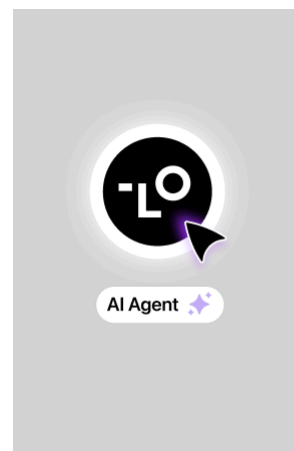
[Gabby Cazeau](#) is a partner at [Harlem Capital](#), investing in pre-seed and seed startups across enterprise software and applied AI. She holds an MBA from Yale and a BS in chemical engineering. Gabby has been featured in Business Insider,

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CNBC, and Crain's 40 Under 40, and serves on the VC Council of Startup:NYC.

[Marlon Nichols](#), co-founder and managing general partner of [MaC Venture Capital](#), leads one of North America's top seed-stage firms with over \$600 million AUM (assets under management). A multiple-time honoree on Business Insider's Seed 100 and PitchBook's list of top Black VCs, Marlon has helped scale industry-shaping companies like Blavity, Thrive Market, and MongoDB.

What to expect on the Builders Stage

This isn't your typical venture panel. Expect sharp insights on how to cut through the noise, structure your raise, and build relationships that last beyond a term sheet. Whether you're gearing up for your first round or advising a founder who is, this is the session you don't want to miss.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

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Catch Palma, Cazeau, Nichols, and [250+ tech heavyweights](#) across the six industry-specific stages, as well as in breakouts and roundtables, live at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025, at Moscone West in San Francisco. [Register now](#) and lock in up to \$675 in ticket savings before today ends!

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